

COMPANION GUIDE

Staying Independent Longer

*A two-part printable companion to the free
Home Safety Walkthrough*



PART 1
**Getting Parents
On Board**

How to open the conversation with warmth, protect dignity, and ease into assistance without resistance.

PART 2
**Practical Solutions
That Help**

Easy-to-use devices and simple home changes that support independence longer — not take it away.

“You take care of everyone. This conversation is one way to keep taking care of each other.”

Use this guide after (or alongside) the free room-by-room Home Safety Walkthrough.
It helps turn the prioritized list into real conversations and gentle next steps.





PART 1

Getting Parents On Board

Most families wait until a fall, a hospital stay, or a crisis forces the conversation. By then, emotions are high and options feel limited. Starting earlier — while things are still mostly fine — gives everyone more room to choose what works.

This is not about convincing anyone they are declining. It is about protecting the independence they already have.

A helpful mindset before you begin

- This conversation is an act of love, not control.
- Your parent still gets to decide. Your role is to bring information, options, and calm support.
- Resistance is often fear of losing control or becoming a burden. Meet the fear, not the argument.
- Small, shared decisions build trust faster than one big “talk.”

When and How to Start

Choose a calm moment — after a meal, during a quiet visit, or while doing something pleasant together. Avoid launching the topic right after a scare or during an argument. If a recent incident happened, acknowledge it gently and shift toward prevention rather than blame.

Gentle conversation openers

“I’ve been thinking about how much we both want you to stay in this house for as long as possible. Would you be open to walking through a few rooms together and just noticing what might make that easier?”

“I noticed the bathroom floor can get slippery. What if we tried one simple change — just to make showers feel more solid under your feet?”

“A lot of families are looking at small upgrades that help people stay independent longer. I found a free checklist we could do together if you’re willing.”

What often sits underneath resistance

When a parent says “I’m fine” or “I don’t need that,” it is rarely about the grab bar or the night light. It is usually about what accepting help might mean.

What they may be feeling	What often helps
Loss of control or independence	Offer choices. “Would you rather try the temporary bar first or look at a few permanent styles together?”
Fear of becoming a burden	Frame changes as tools that reduce worry for everyone. “This helps me worry less so I can enjoy our visits more.”
Embarrassment or pride	Normalize it. “Plenty of people in their 60s and 70s use these so they can keep doing what they love.”
Not wanting things to change	Start with the least visible upgrades: better lighting, clearing a path, a non-slip mat. Build from success.



Easing Into Assistance — Practical Steps

You do not need agreement one very thing at once. Momentum often comes from one small, successful change.

1. Start with the free walkthrough together

Sit side-by-side (or share the screen). Let them check the boxes. The tool generates a prioritized list without judgment. It turns “you need help” into “here’s what the rooms are telling us.”

2. Pick one low-stakes item first

Better lighting in the hallway, a non-slip mat, or clearing a pathway. Success on something easy makes the next conversation softer.

3. Offer trials, not permanent commitments

Temporary suction grab bars, a portable shower chair, or a trial night-light let them experience the benefit without feeling locked in.

4. Let them choose style and placement when possible

Even small decisions restore a sense of control. “Which of these two do you like better?” goes further than “I’m putting this in.”

5. Install or set up together when you can

Shared action reduces the feeling that something is being done “to” them. It becomes something you are doing as a team.

6. Circle back after a short time

“How did the night light feel this week?” invites reflection instead of another hard sell. Adjust based on what they notice.

Remember: The goal is not perfect compliance. The goal is a safer home that still feels like theirs — and a relationship that stays strong enough to keep talking as needs change.

Notes from our conversation

What felt important to them · What they are willing to try · What to revisit later



PART 2

Practical Solutions That Support Independence

The best devices and changes do not announce “you are less capable.” They quietly remove friction so your parent can keep doing the things that matter to them. Below are high-impact, relatively easy options that align with the areas the Home Safety Walkthrough prioritizes.

Focus on what the walkthrough report flagged as High or Medium priority. One or two well-chosen changes often make a bigger difference than a long shopping list. Print the report and divide it between siblings.

Bathroom — Highest Fall Risk, Highest Payoff

Bathrooms account for a large share of home falls. The good news: many effective solutions are temporary, reversible, and relatively inexpensive.

- **Grab bars (temporary or permanent)**

Temporary suction cups let someone try the feeling before committing. Permanent bars (properly installed into studs) are more reliable long-term. Place near the toilet and inside the shower/tub. Look for textured grips.

- **Raised toilet seat or toilet safety frame**

Reduces the distance to sit and stand. Frames with arms give leverage. Many models install without tools and can be removed later.

- **Shower chair or transfer bench**

Allows sitting while bathing. Transfer benches that extend outside the tub are especially helpful if stepping over a high side is hard. Choose one with a back and non-slip feet.

- **Handheld shower head**

Pairs well with a shower seat. Lets the person control water direction without standing or twisting. Easy to install on most existing fixtures.

- **Non-slip mats or adhesive strips**

Inside the tub/shower and just outside. Choose ones that drain well and can be cleaned. Avoid thick rugs that create a trip edge. Tip for introduction: “A lot of people use a seat and a handheld shower so they can take their time and still feel steady. Want to try one for a couple of weeks and see how it feels?”



Lighting & Clear Pathways

Falls often happen at night or in transition spaces. Good light and clear routes are among the least “medical” improvements you can make.

- **Motion-sensor or plug-in night lights**

Path from bed to bathroom is a classic risk zone. Soft ,automatic light reduces the need to fumble for switches. Warm(not blue-white) tones feel less clinical.

- **Brighter, non-glare bulbs in key areas**

Hallways, stairs, entries, and bathrooms. Higher lumen LEDs with a soft white color temperature improve visibility without harshness.

- **Clear floors and secured or removed throw rugs**

Rugs are a top trip hazard .If a rug stays, use a quality non-slip pad underneath and ensure edges lie flat. Best option is often to remove high-risk ones.

- **Handrails on stairs (both sides when possible)**

One solid rail is better than none; two is better still. Rails that extend a bit past the top and bottom steps give a place to hold while starting or finishing.

Entry, Thresholds & Everyday Helpers

- **Lever-style door handles**

Easier than round knobs when grip strength or arthritis is an issue. A simple swap that feels like a home upgrade rather than an adaptation.

- **Threshold ramps or bevels**

Small height differences at a door scan catch a foot or walker. Low-profile rubber or wood bevels smooth the transition without a major remodel.

- **Improved outdoor lighting at entries and paths**

Motion lights or dusk-to-dawn fixtures make arriving home and navigating steps safer after dark.

- **Reacher / grabber tools**

Extend reach for items on high shelves or the floor without climbing or bending deeply. Lightweight models with comfortable grips are easiest to use.

- **Sturdy chair or transfer pole near the bed**

A stable place to sit while dressing ,or a vertical pole for steadying when standing from bed, can reduce risk without feeling institutional.

From the Walkthrough Report — Our First Priorities

List the High or Medium items you both agreed to address first. Keep it short.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

What we will try this month

Bringing It Together

The Home Safety Walkthrough gives you a clear, prioritized picture of the physical environment. This companion guide helps with the human side — the conversation, the pacing, and the practical tools that turn a list into safer days.

You do not have to solve everything at once. One successful small change often opens the door to the next conversation. Keep the tone warm, keep the focus on independence, and keep showing up.

*“Decisions made before a crisis are usually better than decisions made during one.
You are doing the hard, quiet work of preparing the ground.”*

Next Steps

1. Complete (or revisit) the free Home Safety Walkthrough together. Print the walkthrough report when you're done.
2. Use Part 1 of this guide to open or continue the conversation.
3. Choose one or two high-priority, low-resistance changes from Part 2.
4. Try them. Notice what helps. Adjust. Talk again when ready.

Other free tools at thepreparedlifestore.com that may help once the home feels safer:

• Caregiver Burnout Check-In · Family Meeting Facilitator · Elder Care Cost Estimator · Can They Still Live Alone? Assessment

If this helped your family, a review means everything to a small shop. Thank you for being here.

Life happens. Best have a plan.



Every checklist...
Every worksheet...
Every printable...
was designed to stack together. No duplicate pages.
No starting over.
Just keep building your family's care binder as your journey changes.

